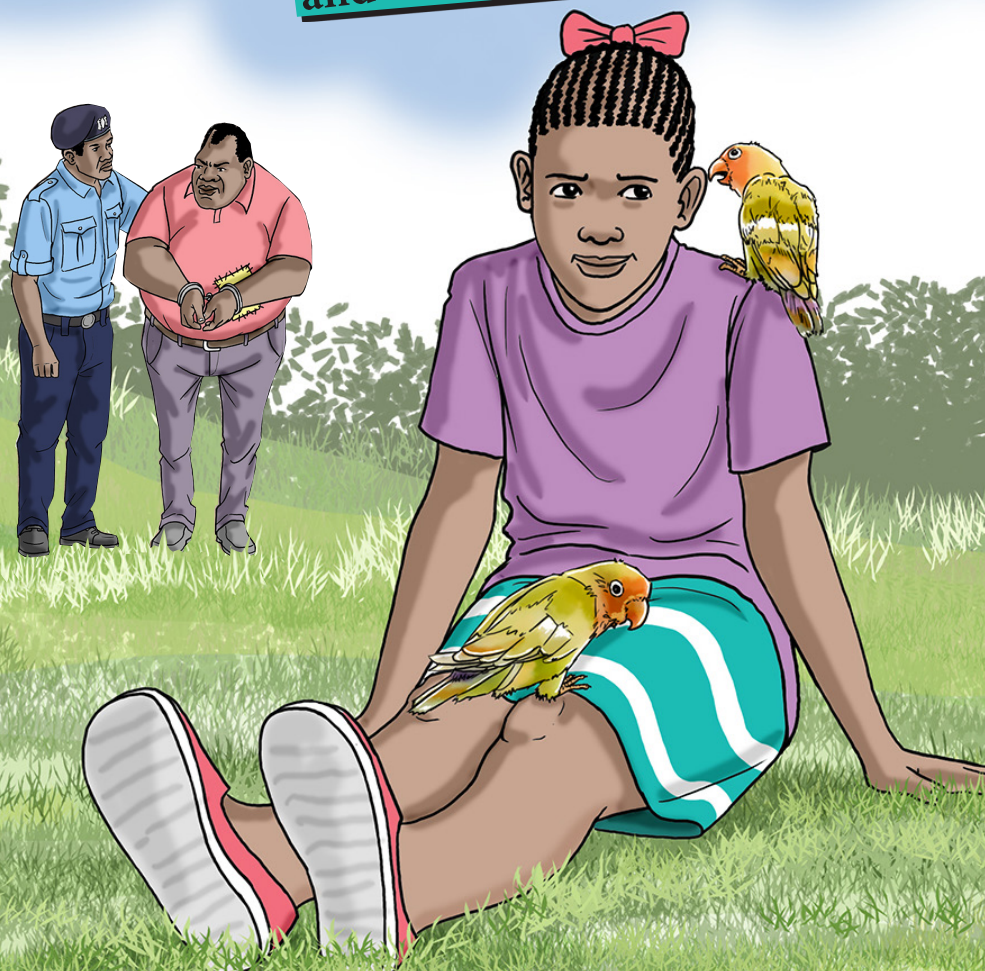


Amara

the Hero

and Other Stories





Amara

the Hero
and Other Stories

A book based on true stories is best dedicated to those in reality who have gone through pain and agony. This is to all children who have gone through sexual abuse, you are our silent heroes.

'Amara, the Hero and Other Stories'

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Amara the Hero

In a small village far away lived a courageous, kind-hearted young girl. Amara loved playing football on Saturdays.

Her wish was to become a footballer.

In red rubber shoes, she kicked the ball so hard that one shoe flew off with the ball, into a swamp nearby.

Amara boldly stepped into the muddy swamp to pick up the ball and her red shoe.

The other children cheered.

After the football game, Amara walked home.

"Father, I'm home," she shouted from their small gate as she walked towards father sitting under a palm tree.

Her home had many palm trees and a few coconut trees.

Just like her father, Amara also liked sitting under the palm trees, watching the many birds that had made nests in the branches.



One day, while returning home from her football match, she saw a young boy peeping from a window.

He was inside the house that belonged to Clay, a White man who drove a big car.

The boy looked sad and lonely.

Most times, the house deep in the woods was locked but Amara had seen the White man a few times.

Amara was curious about the sad boy.

"Is he in danger?" she wondered.

"Does he need my help?"

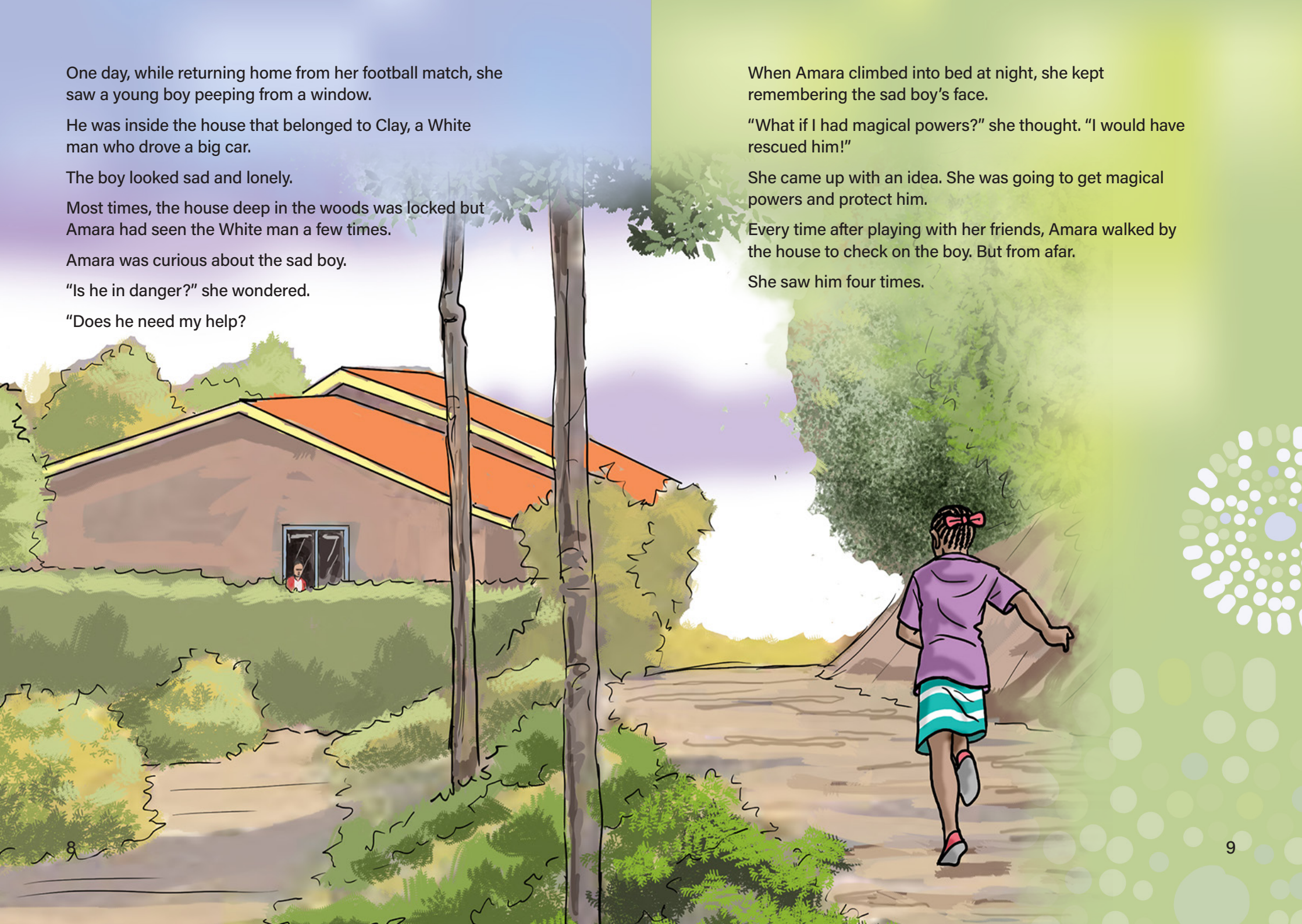
When Amara climbed into bed at night, she kept remembering the sad boy's face.

"What if I had magical powers?" she thought. "I would have rescued him!"

She came up with an idea. She was going to get magical powers and protect him.

Every time after playing with her friends, Amara walked by the house to check on the boy. But from afar.

She saw him four times.



One day, she looked out the window, hoping to see the boy. He was not there. Instead, two lovebirds were perching at the window. The two birds had an orange neck, and red beak, and the top of the head was green.

She stood there staring at the beautiful birds but also waiting for the boy to come to the window.

"Where are you?" she said rather loudly, but careful not to be too loud that someone hears her.

Then suddenly the birds flew towards Amara and perched on her shoulder.



Then magic happened. The two birds started telling her the story of the young boy.

His name is Umi.

"He needs your help," the lovebird on the left said.

"You must tell the police that Umi is locked in the house. And every time the man comes back, he hurts him," the lovebird on the right said.

"When he brought Umi to the house he told him that he was his friend, the one they had been talking to on phone for many years," the lovebird on the left said.

But days later, the birds heard Umi crying.

The lovebirds told Amara how Umi met Mr. Clay. Umi's parents had bought him a laptop and a mobile phone. At home, he took photos of his bedroom, and himself and posted them on Facebook.

One day, he got a friend request from Clay. At first, Clay pretended he was the same age as Umi, a 10-year-old.

Clay asked Umi about his school, where he lived, and his favourite food.

He also asked him to show him their house, on video.

"You can trust me, even with secrets," Clay once told Umi.

Umi was happy he had found a very good friend.

After school, he rushed home to talk to Clay on the Internet.

"You're spending a lot of time in your room, on your mobile phone and laptop. Who do you talk to?" one day Umi's mother asked.

"A friend mother, a very good friend," he said, rushing to his room to talk to Clay.

One day, Clay told Umi that he had two secrets. He told him not to tell anyone.

"Am I your good friend?" he asked.

"Yes!" Umi answered with excitement.

"Friends share secrets. Don't tell your parents because they won't understand us. Parents are always telling us what to do," Clay said.

Umi swore not to share the secrets.

"I want you to come to visit me in Pwani. It is a town near the ocean," Clay said.

"Second secret, I'm not 10 years old. I lied because I wanted to be your friend."

At first, Umi wanted to tell his parents but remembered Clay was his best friend.

He told him to keep a secret.

One Saturday morning, Umi's mobile phone rang. He rushed outside.

He had lied to his mother that he was going to pick a book from a friend.

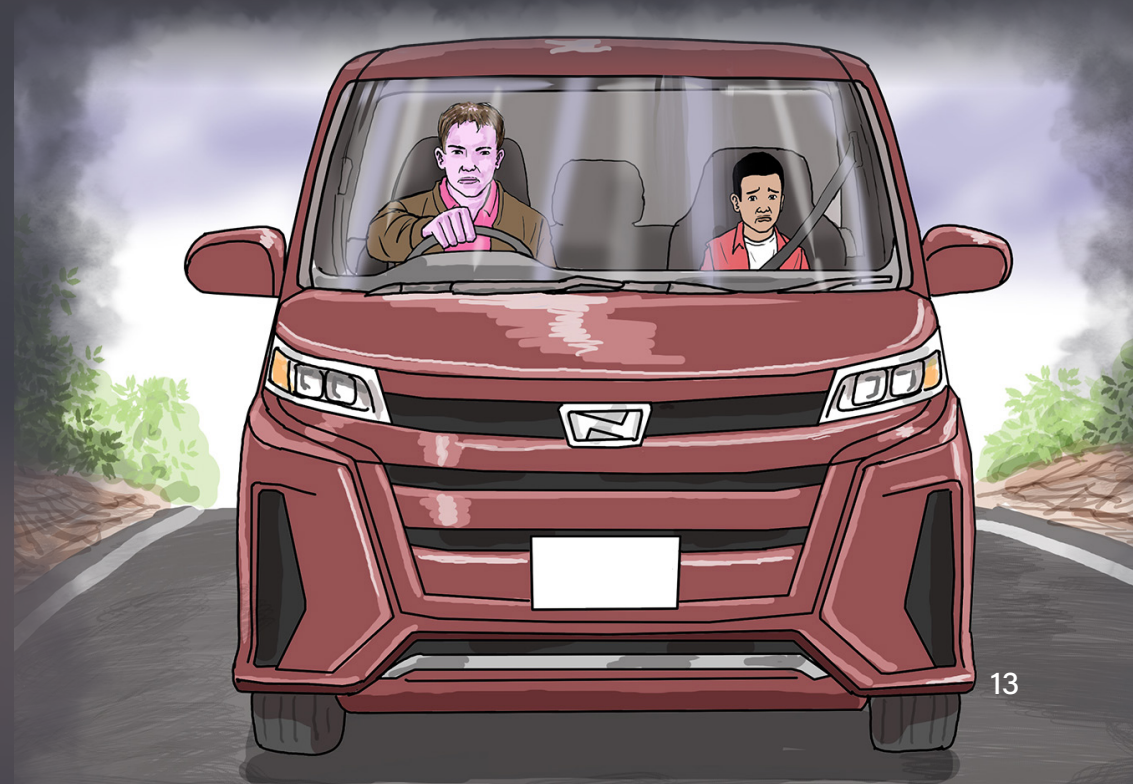
"I forgot my textbook in school," he lied.

Clay was waiting in his car. A big maroon car. Umi spotted the car at the corner. He rushed and immediately jumped in. Clay hugged him tightly.

He was happy to finally meet his friend, he thought.

Clay drove the car towards Matano Road and out of the city.

The journey took many hours. On reaching his house, Clay turned into a monster. He tied Umi's feet and hands and did terrible things to him.



Day and night Umi cried for help but the house was deep in the woods. No one could hear him.

He sat by the closed window hoping that someone saw him.

Every day, two lovebirds perched at the window and chirped, "Chwi, chwi."

"You must save Umi," the lovebirds told Amara.

Amara knew she must rescue the young boy.

She ran through the woods to the police station.

"Mr. Policeman, Mr. Policeman!" she shouted.

"There's a boy in the woods," she said.

"The lovebirds say he is in danger," she continued. "He needs help!"

"We were taught in school the police keep children safe and protect us. Rescue him," Amara said.

Three policemen jumped into a car and asked Amara to go with them.

"Wee-oww, wee-oww," the car sirens wailed towards the woods.

Amara showed the police the house, and the sad little boy by the window.

The police knocked down the door and found Umi, his hands were tied using a rope.

"Young boy, we'll take you home," one of the policemen told him as he cut the rope. Mr. Clay was arrested.



After days in the hospital, Umi's parents took him home.

Umi wrote a letter to Amara.

Dear Amara,

Thank you. You saved me!

My parents were so worried. They even announced on TV that I had been kidnapped by a bad man doing terrible things to children.

You're a hero!

I'll never agree to be friends with a person I meet on the Internet.

I have to tell my parents or my teacher about strangers I met on the Internet.

Your new friend, Umi

A Horrible Uncle

Didi lay still in the bush as the frogs croaked.
"Kroo kroo kroo," she sang along with them.

It was a night of a full moon. It was warm and peaceful, except for the croaking frogs.

"Perhaps it's almost morning. Everyone in the village will soon be awake," she thought to herself.

In the moonlight, she could see her evil uncle in grey boots, staggering to the edge of the fence. He looked and looked but he could not see her. She was hiding deep in the bush.



The bad uncle went back inside the house. She sighed in relief and slept on the grass, only to be woken up by the bright sun.

"Now I must run to Aziza's home," she thought, almost saying it out loud.

She dusted the grass and a few leaves off her hair. She straightened her creased dress and started running very fast to Aziza's home.

Aziza's mother was milking the cow.

"Didi, my child, why are you up so early? Aziza is not yet ready for school," Aziza's mother said in her usual bright mood.

"Did you have breakfast already?"

The two girls had been friends since Grade 2 and Aziza's mother had grown fond of Didi, especially after her parents died in a road accident.

Immediately, Didi burst out crying.

Mama Aziza rushed and held the girl's hand, knocking the milk jar along the way.

"What is it? What is it Didi? Come inside the house," she said surprised, holding the young girl who was still sobbing.

They sat on the chair and Didi revealed how her uncle had abused her. Didi kept wiping tears off her face.

"I've been hiding in the bush," Didi murmured softly, as if talking to herself.

"Did he do something awful to you? Please tell me," Mama Aziza insisted.

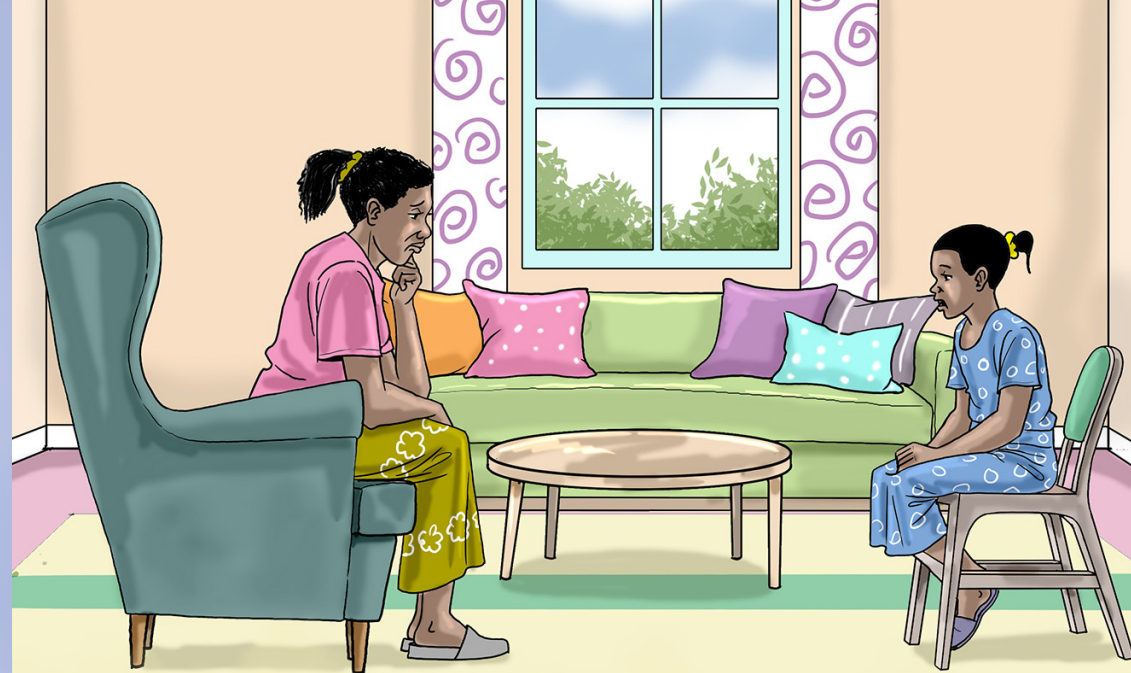
When her parents died, Uncle Ali picked young Didi from the city to live with her in a small beautiful village in Kulecho. Life in the village was different but she had started loving it.

"What is it? What is it Didi? Come inside the house," she said surprised, holding the young girl who was still sobbing.

They sat on the chair and Didi revealed how her uncle had abused her.

During sunny days, trees lining up the walkways bloomed. Red and purple flowers fell from the trees. On her way to school, Didi dragged her feet through the flowers, while singing;

Mr Tree, Tree, Tree, how did your flowers grow?
Like purple tiny bells
Like red tiny bells



Sometimes Uncle Ali walked her to school. Uncle Ali and Didi got along so well. He was funny and friendly and together they picked some flowers.

But when she reached nine years, Uncle Ali became wicked. Every night, he asked young Didi to play bad games.

"He comes home after drinking alcohol, walks into my bedroom, switches off the lights and tells me to remove my clothes. Yesterday, I refused and he slapped me," Didi said.

"When did he start doing this?" Mama Aziza asked.

"Since I was nine years old. He said it was a game of removing clothes. He said if I removed the clothes faster than him he will buy me viazi karai. Then he touches me and calls me a beautiful young woman," Didi murmured.

"When the teacher told us in school that a man should not touch our bodies, I started refusing. Then uncle beat me. I ran away and hid in the bush," she said.

Mama Aziza hugged Didi.

"I want us to go to the clinic in Kulecho and the doctors can check if Uncle Ali hurt you. Don't be scared, Okay?" Didi nodded.

"Is it my fault?" she asked quietly as Mama Aziza unwrapped her lesa from her waist and covered the little girl.

"You may feel bad because of what Ali had been doing to you, but you're a child. You wanted your uncle to love you like his own child. He hurt you," Mama Aziza said.

"But don't tell uncle I told you because he might be angry. He will not want to live with me," Didi said as they walked into the clinic.

Mama Aziza explained to Didi what he had told her daughter Aziza about our bodies.

"Didi, listen to me carefully. There is a difference between a good and bad touch. And no one should touch your private parts. A father or uncle's way of showing love is different from what your Uncle Ali was doing," she said, calming down the girl by rubbing her hair.

"I'm so sorry this happened to you. We always think people who hurt children are creepy strangers. No. Sometimes the people we love and trust can harm us. If someone touches you and it doesn't feel right, or tells you to remove your clothes, you speak up and tell. Your body belongs to you. Not to uncle or anyone else. And I'm so happy you came to me. Now Ali will not hurt you anymore," Mama Aziza said.

"Sometimes, there are dangerous people everywhere: at the bus stop, around the school, in our homes, and even on the streets. These people do bad things to children," she said.

The doctor checked Didi's body and gave her some medicines.

He also told her that she will talk to a counsellor to help her get better.

Mama Aziza told Didi that she will now live at her house and share a bedroom with her best friend Aziza.

One morning, Aziza and Didi were sleeping when they heard a siren.

"Wee-oww, wee-oww," the police car passed behind their home. "Is that a police car?" Aziza asked Didi.

The girls peeped through the window and saw neighbours following the police car.

"Mother, mother, there's a police car outside," Aziza and Didi shouted.

"Yes, it is. Ali, your uncle, is going to be arrested," she said, hugging both girls tightly.

"Bad men are jailed for many, many years," she said.





The Video Games Bait

Omari was a quiet boy. He never played much. Only when he went to Mzee Lekei's house.

"I'm going to Mzee Lekei's house to play video games," he told his mother on his way out.

The old man was known by all his neighbours as jovial. He liked children. He lived alone in a big compound.

"The boys can come anytime to my house to play. I have plenty of video games, a basketball court and lots of food for them to eat," he told their parents.

And Omari and five other boys loved visiting him.

One day, mother got home and Omari had not yet arrived.

"Where is Omari?" his mother asked his younger sister Lulu.

Lulu said his brother was at Mzee Lekei's house.

It was 6 pm but mother was not so worried because the boys liked the old man and kept him company.

"Poor Mzee Lekei, he's always alone. But the boys have spent enough time with him now. Go call your brother, it's getting dark," mother told Lulu.

The young girl rushed out. Luckily, she found her brother walking back home. He was limping. He looked very sad.

"Did you hurt your leg while playing basketball with Mzee Lekei and your friends?" Lulu asked. "Mother is home, she will look at your leg and apply medicine."

Omari did not tell his sister that it wasn't his leg that was paining. Slowly, he walked home.

When Omari reached the house, he sat in a corner. He kept to himself.

"How's Mzee Lekei? Did he give you any chicken today? I like how he cooks the chicken curry," mother said.

"No," Omari said quietly his mother could barely hear him.

"Are you okay? Are you coming up with a cold?" she stood up touching her son's forehead to check if he had a fever.

"No, mother. I'm well," he said.

Omari stopped going to Mzee Lekei's house to play video games.



After school, he sat by himself. At school, he was also sad. Sometimes his sister found him crying.

"What's wrong? Are you sick?" the sister asked.

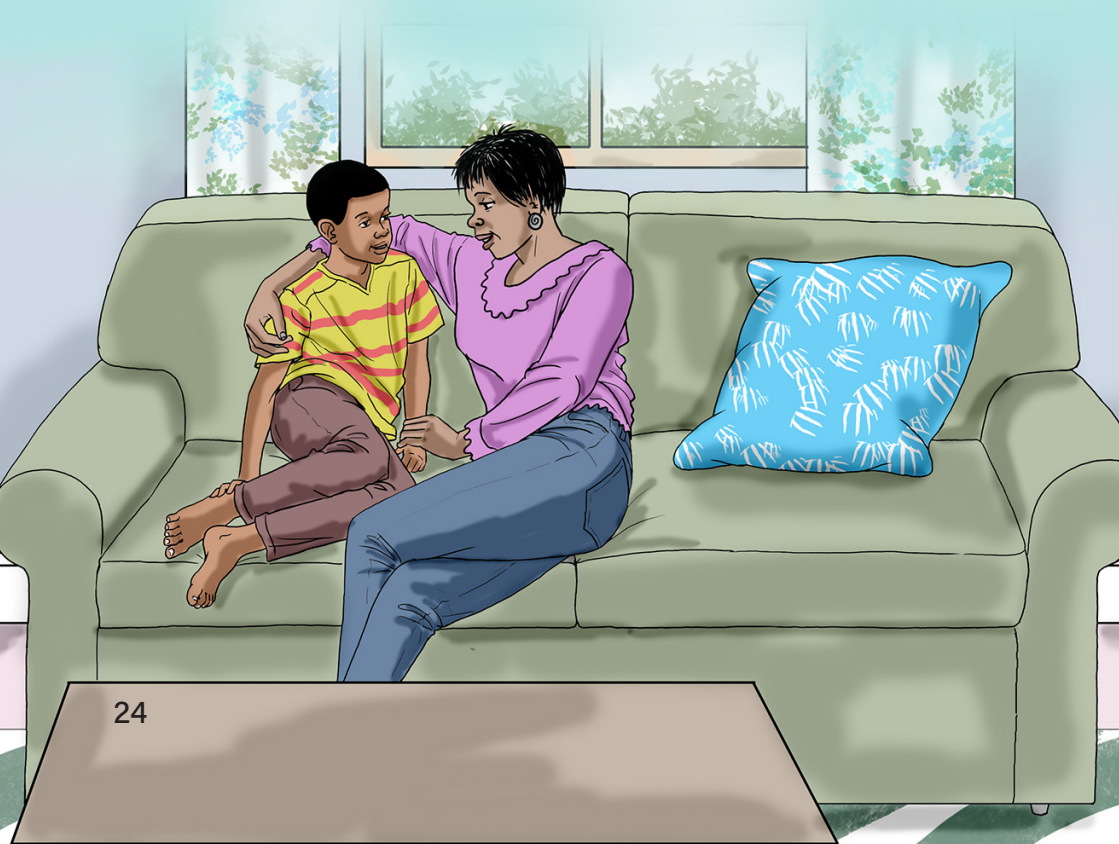
But Omari lied that he had a stomachache after eating pumpkin.

One day, at the market, mother heard that Mzee Lekei had been arrested by the police. The policemen said he raped many boys.

She had rushed home.

"Omari, Omari!" mother shouted.

"Beno has told the policemen that Mzee Lekei also hurt you. My boy, please tell me. Did he ever do anything bad to you?" mother asked with tears in her eyes.



She didn't want to believe that Mzee Lekei had hurt her son. But he had.

"Mother, I was scared of telling you. Mzee Lekei said if we tell our parents, he will kill them. And also kill us. We played bad video games, then he gave us food. We never knew what happened later because we woke up in his bed with pain here," Omari said crying, pointing his to backside.

"The police said he put bad drugs in the food. The drugs made you sleep," mother said.

"Show me where he hurt you. I'm not going to punish you."

Mother checked Omari before taking him to the hospital for treatment. Soon he started talking to a counsellor to help him heal. Together with his sister and the other children, his mother told them about bad people who scare children.

"Bad people lie and promise children gifts. No matter what they say, don't be scared to tell your parents or teachers," she said.

Beno's mother told the children, "If someone touches your body, say, 'No, stop it. I don't want to be touched.' Say it out loud. Your body is special, it belongs only to you," she said.

"Sometimes if you say, 'stop it,' some bad people may keep on touching you. Don't keep quiet, tell someone you trust. You should have told us about Mzee Lekei," mother said.

"What about sitting on a stranger's lap?" Beno asked tapping on his thighs.

"Mr Lekei used to tell me to sit on his lap."

"No, don't sit on a man's lap," Beno's mother said.

"Sometimes you may not know if the man is doing a bad or good thing. That's why you ask a trusted teacher or parent. Don't be afraid to ask," Beno's mother told the children.

Atieno and her Best friend Solo

Atieno woke up early to go to church. She wanted to be a priest when she grows up.

She was an altar girl. She helped the priest. Her duty was to hold candles for the priest when he read the Bible.

"Father, I must be early today," she shouted.

Father was feeding the cows. Father and Atieno's younger brother Asingo were to go for the second mass.

It was Sunday at 6.30 am. The village was quiet. Most people were still asleep because it was a weekend.

"Be careful my daughter," Father said. "And here, have this," father gave her church offering.

Atieno put the money in her pocket and dashed out.

Her favourite dog, Solo wagged its tail. It licked her feet. This was its way to show Atieno that it loved her.



Solo and Atieno were good friends. They were like two peas in a pod. Where Atieno was, Solo was not too far away. She always felt brave and strong when with Solo.

The young girl went with Solo to the market and to the river. When she returned home from school, Solo was always waiting for her at the gate.

Most days, Solo slept on the floor next to Atieno's bed.

"I wish I could go with Solo to church," she thought.

There was no one on the road but Atieno was not afraid because church was not very far.

So she kept walking.

Suddenly a young man jumped out of a bush and grabbed Atieno.

He started dragging her into the bush.

Atieno screamt.

"Father, father, heeeelp!"

Another young man came from another bush.

He started tearing her clothes.

Atieno screamt again.

"Father, father, they want to kill me!"

The young men threw her down and tore her blouse. The buttons flew off.

Then they tore her pleated yellow skirt.

She kept shouting.

"Help! Help! Please! Anyone!"

Then she whistled. It was a secret way that the two, Atieno and Solo, communicated.

Solo heard Atieno's whistle.

He came running and barking fiercely.

He jumped on the men and bite them on the neck and leg.

They ran away. Solo followed them. He was a big dog. He jumped on one man.

When father saw Solo running, he knew his daughter was in danger.

He too followed Solo.

"Help! Help," he shouted. "Please help my daughter," he yelled when he saw naked Atieno.

Villagers came running. They covered Atieno with sweaters.

Then they heard Solo barking a distance from Atieno.

They rushed there and found the bad young man. Solo has bitten his neck and leg. He was bleeding. Solo's teeth were deep in his leg so that he couldn't run away. The other man had escaped.

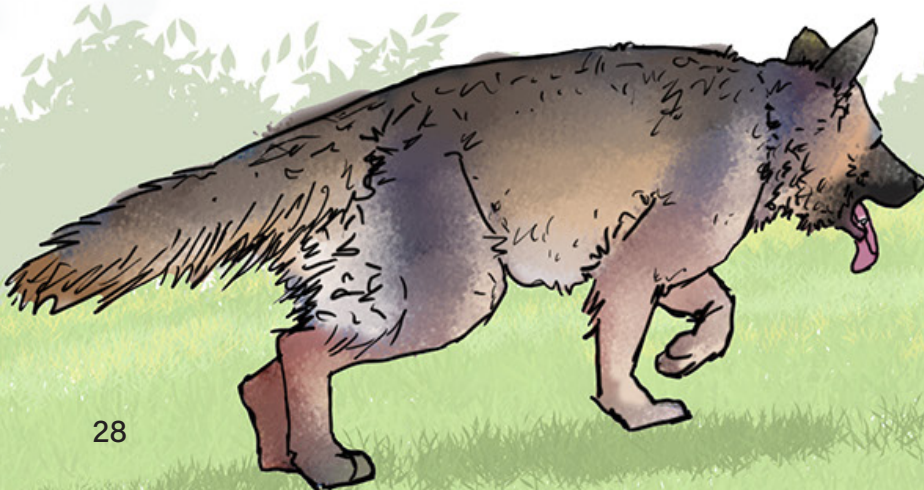
The villagers frogmarched the man to the police station.

Father took Atieno to the hospital. Solo was by Atieno's side throughout.

"Okay, Solo, you're a good dog. You rescued Atieno but you cannot come inside the hospital," the doctor told the dog, while rubbing his back.

Solo wagged its tail. It licked Atieno's feet again. Then he sat outside the hospital's door.

"I'm okay Solo. I will never walk alone. I will always walk with you. You protect me from bad people," Atieno told Solo and entered the hospital with father and the doctor.



Naliaka and the Secret

Naliaka is still in bed. It is almost school time but the little girl has not woken up.

"Hurry up, you will be late for school," Naliaka's mother says.

Mother walks into her daughter's bedroom and finds her still covered in blankets.

The sun is already shining bright. She opens the curtains, then sees her crying.

Naliaka quickly turns her face towards the wall to hide. But mother has already seen the tears.

She asked her daughter gently, "Are you sick?"

Naliaka keeps quiet. She wants to tell her mother about the secret in apartment 8B, but remembers her best friend Naeku.



"This is our secret. Don't share with anyone, even your mother," Naeku told her.

Naliaka never lies to mother.

"I should tell mother," she thought. "But will Naeku be my friend if I share the secret?" she wondered.

Mother realised that Naliaka was hiding something. She asked her to sit up. The little girl tried to sit up but could not. She was in pain.

"I hurt my leg," she said. "While playing at Naliaka's birthday party yesterday."

"Let me see," mother said, moving the blanket aside. Then she saw blood on Naliaka's bedsheets.

"Ohh! What happened?" Mother asked. "Your leg must be hurting so much it is bleeding."

Mother told her daughter to dress up so that they go to the hospital.

Naliaka started getting worried that the doctor will find out that her leg is okay.

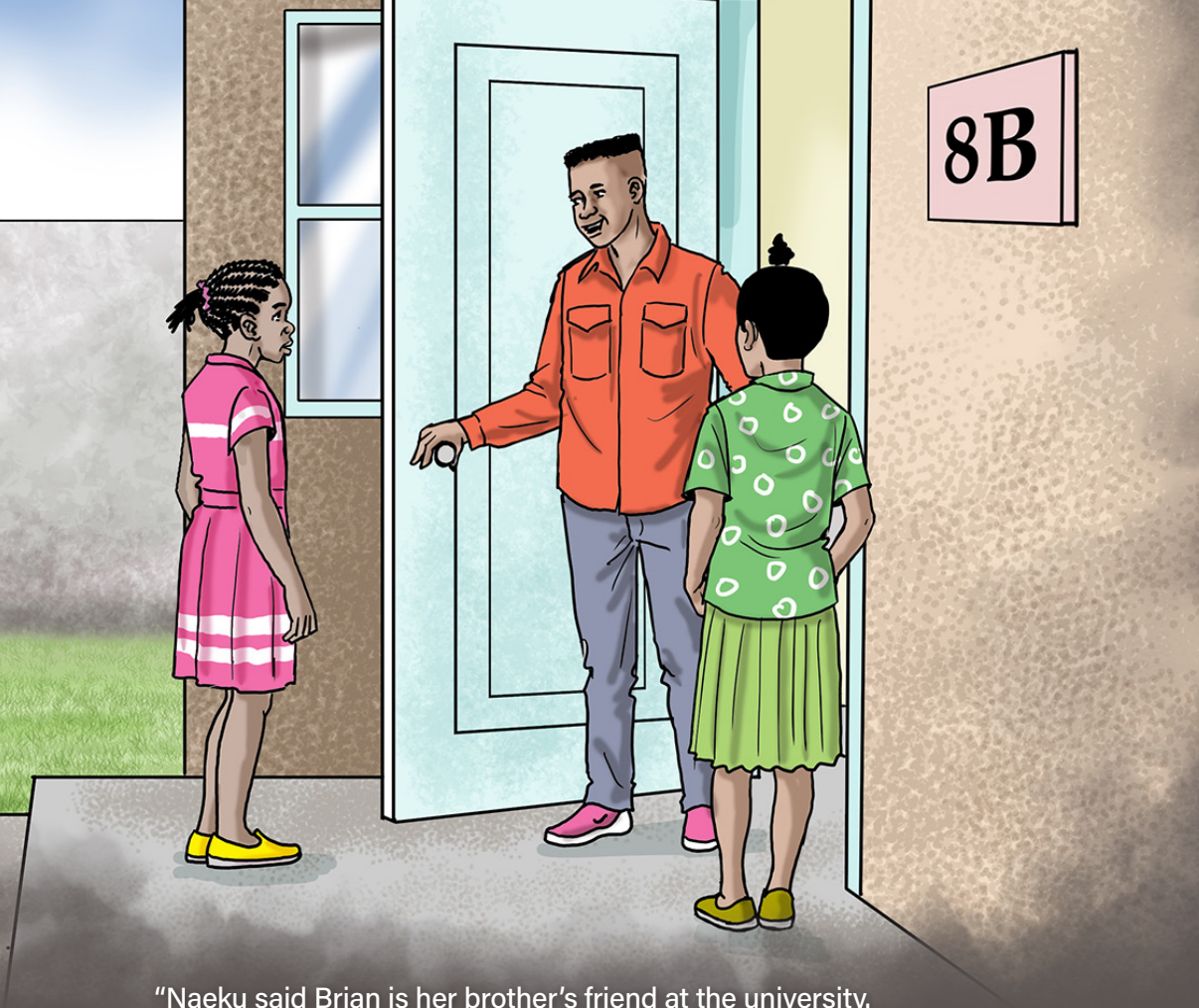
She knew she had to break the promise she made to her friend.

"Mum, Naeku took me to her friend's house. His name is Brian," she said while using the pillow to cover her face.

Mother looked shocked.

"He lives in apartment 8B. I'm sorry I didn't tell you yesterday," Naliaka continued.

"Did he touch you? Did he touch you Naliaka?" Mother said.



"Naeku said Brian is her brother's friend at the university. She said he was not a stranger so it was okay to go to his house," Naliaka quickly said.

She was afraid that mother will beat her. Mother had warned against going to a stranger's home.

"Did he hurt you?" Mother asked again.

Naliaka kept quiet. Naeku had told her to keep the secret. Brian had promised to give them mobile phones and chocolates as gifts if they kept the secret.

8B

"What if Naeku stops being my friend?" Naliaka wondered again.

Mother was getting more worried. She knew Naliaka was keeping a bad secret.

"There are secrets we should not keep. Don't be scared, my daughter. Nothing will happen to you or your friend," Mother said calmly.

She decided to take Naliaka to the hospital. Father went too.

At the hospital, the counsellor told Naliaka, "Did you know bad secrets make you feel bad and worry a lot? The only way to make you feel better is to tell your mummy, daddy, teacher, or me."

Naliaka agreed to tell them about Brian who lives in apartment 8B and the secret.

"Brian raped you and your friend Naeku. It is a crime," the counsellor said.

"What is rape?" Naliaka asked.

"Rape is a wrong thing. It is someone doing something bad with your body. No one should touch you or ask you to touch them," the counselor said.

"If you kept a secret about someone who hurt you as Brian did, is that a bad or good secret?" the counsellor asked Naliaka.

"A bad secret," Naliaka answered.

"Yes, you're right, because it's not okay for someone to hurt you. Telling a bad secret that makes you sad is a very good thing to do," the counsellor said.

Naliaka visited the counsellor for many months. She felt better.

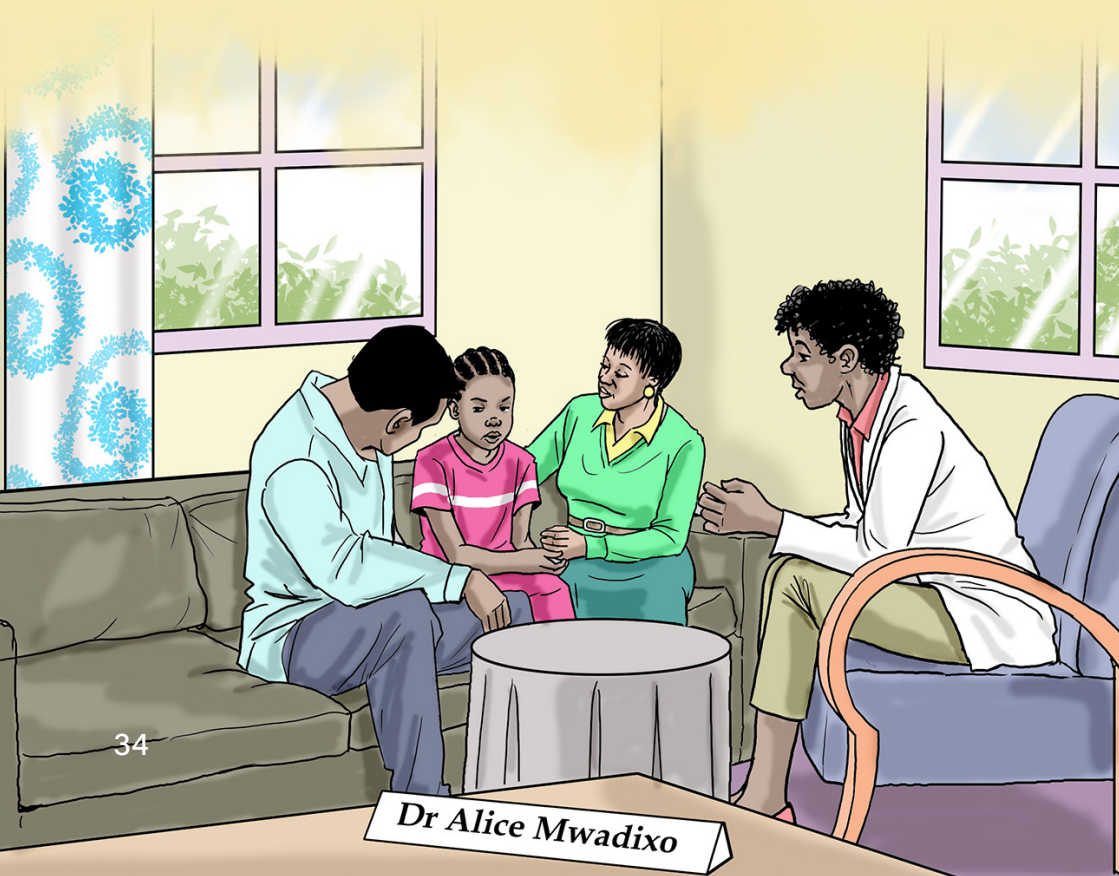
Brian was arrested and stayed in prison for 15 years.

Naeku and Naliaka ended their friendship.

Naliaka grew up healthier.

She finished university last month.

She is now a lawyer helping children.



New words

Rape: A wrong thing where someone forces you to do something with your body. A man or woman can force you to touch their private parts. No one should touch you or ask you to touch their private parts.

Courageous: A person who does not fear

Chirp: The sounds that birds make

Rescue: To save someone from danger

Altar girl: A girl who helps the priest during a Mass

Abuse: To treat someone with cruelty or violence. For example, children can face sexual abuse or physical abuse.

Perch: To sit near the edge of a chair, a tree, or a window

Abuse: To treat someone with cruelty or violence. For example, children can face sexual abuse or physical abuse.

Croaking: A deep sound that frogs make

Awful: A very bad thing

Sighed in relief: To feel happy that something unpleasant has not happened

New words

Drag: To pull someone forcefully

Creepy: A frightening person

Lovebirds: A type of colourful birds

Counsellor: A person who has been trained to do the job of listening to people who have problems and help them get better

Frogmarched: To force someone who is unwilling to move forward by holding the hands behind their back and then pushing them forward

Murmured: Talk in a low voice

Bait: A trap

Bloom: Produce flowers

Creased: Something like a dress or shirt that is wrinkled that needs ironing

A bad drug: A pill or powder that if swallowed or sniffed, it makes someone not know what is happening or do things they cannot remember

Peeped: Look through a small space

Questions

1. What did you learn from these stories?

2. What was the brave girl's name who saved Umi from a bad man's house?

3. Which birds told Amara that Umi needed help?

4. What happened to Omari?

5. abused Omari.

6. Write two things we should do if someone does terrible things to our bodies?

7. Who should we tell if someone touches our private parts?

Questions

8. We use Internet in school and at home. Can we become friends with strangers on the Internet? Yes or No.

9. Why should we not talk to strangers on the Internet?

10. Who abused Didi?

11. Bad people lie to children that they will them. Or they will give them presents such as and

12. What prizes did the bad man give to Naliaka and Naeku?

13. What is rape?

